Ice Age. Compared to R1a1, India has relatively low concentrations of R1b. My interpretation is that we are dealing with two major genetic dispersals occurring from the Persian Gulf-Makran-Gujarat region at different points in the climatic cycle—one occurred at the onset or during the last Ice Age with R1b carriers heading mostly west, and another occurred around the time of the Flood involving R1a1 carriers.

The genetic and cultural links between North Indians and eastern Iranians are due to the second dispersal but possibly with additional inputs from a later migration of some lineages north-westward from India. [28] As we shall see in the next chapter, there is reason to believe that some Indian tribes moved westward to Iran and beyond during the Bronze Age. In addition, cultural linkages could have been kept alive by trade. The spread of Indian culture to South East Asia in ancient times and, more recently, the accelerated popularity of the English language in the post-colonial period show that one does not need either conquest or large-scale migration to drive linguistic and cultural exchange. The reality of complex back-and-forth linkages make it very difficult to decode history using the linguistic layers. This may explain why traditional timelines based on linguistics were far shorter than those being suggested now by genetics and archaeology.

CASTES OR TRIBES?

There is one further insight that genetics hints at—the dynamics of India's caste system. India is not unique in having developed a caste system. Through history we have seen different versions of the caste system in Japan, Iran, and even in Classical Europe. What is remarkable about Indian castes is their persistence over thousands of years despite changes in technology, political conditions, and even religion. The system has even survived centuries of strong criticism and opposition from within the Hindu tradition.

It was once thought that the caste system had something to do with the Aryan influx and the imposition of a rigid racial hierarchy. However, as geneticist Sanghamitra Sahoo and her team have shown: 'The Y-